Draft Ballot Argument
City Manager Authority to Settle Claims
Charter Section 1314

Arguments in support or opposition of the proposed laws are the opinions of the authors.

Argument in Favor of Measure ☒
[or]
Argument Against Measure ☐

[Pursuant to §9282: Maximum 300 words]

Vote YES to cut bureaucratic red tape and save valuable public meeting time.

Would you run your household or business using financial rules that have been frozen since 1989? Of course not. But that is exactly what Sunnyvale's existing City Charter does.

Currently, the City Manager's authority to settle even routine, clear-cut legal claims is capped at just $50,000—a **limit set nearly 40 years ago**. Because of decades of inflation, $50,000 in 1989 is worth over $130,000 today. As a result, even minor administrative claims —like a city vehicle clipping a fender—frequently exceed this low threshold.

This creates a bureaucratic bottleneck. Your elected City Council is forced to repeatedly stop their work to agendize, review, and vote on minor, routine legal settlements. This wastes taxpayer-funded staff hours, delays fair resolutions for residents, and clutters public meetings.

Voting **YES** replaces this rigid, outdated $50,000 cap and empowers the City Council to set realistic limits by ordinance. In July, Council passed an ordinance to set this threshold to XXXXX thousand dollars if this measure passes. This directly aligns settlement authority with the City Manager's existing day-to-day purchasing and contract approval limits.

This measure maintains strict, absolute accountability:

- **Preserves Council Oversight:** Your elected City Council retains exclusive authority to review and vote on all major, high-dollar legal settlements.
- **Protects Public Resources:** Resolving minor claims quickly saves city staff hours, avoids protracted litigation, and reduces overall legal expenses.
- **Focuses on Priorities:** Clears the clutter from Council agendas so your leaders can focus on critical community issues like housing, traffic, and public safety.

Vote YES for efficient, accountable, and modernized city management.